

THE INFINITIVE & THE GERUND

A Comprehensive Guide to Verb Forms in English

Forms

Structures

Verb Lists

Examples

What Is the Infinitive?

TO-INFINITIVE

to + base form of verb

I want to speak.

She hopes to travel.

We decided to leave.

BARE INFINITIVE

base form (without 'to')

She made us wait.

John lets the dog sleep.

He helped me carry it.

Forms of the Infinitive

Present Infinitive

to work / to do

I want to learn English.

Present Continuous

to be Ving

She seems to be enjoying the party.

Perfect Infinitive

to have V3/ed

He claims to have met the President.

Perfect Continuous Inf.

to have been Ving

They appeared to have been waiting.

Present Infinitive Passive

to be V3/ed

This task needs to be completed today.

Perfect Infinitive Passive

to have been V3/ed

The work appears to have been done.

Infinitive as Subject

Used with: appear • be • seem → always followed by a SINGULAR verb

DIRECT STRUCTURE

To compromise appears advisable.

To go overseas alone is very brave.

To lean out of the window is dangerous.

To save money seems impossible.

To have made the same mistake was unforgivable.



IT-STRUCTURE (preferred)

It appears advisable to compromise.

It is very brave to go overseas alone.

It is dangerous to lean out of the window.

It seems impossible to save money.

It was unforgivable to have made the same mistake.

Infinitive as Complement

S + V (any tense) + Infinitive + C/M

agree

aim

appear

arrange

ask

attempt

bother

care

choose

claim

condescend

consent

decide

decline

demand

determine

endeavor

fail

forget

guarantee

happen

hesitate

hope

learn

long

manage

neglect

offer

plan

prepare

pretend

proceed

promise

prove

refuse

remember

resolve

seem

swear

tend

threaten

try

undertake

volunteer

vow

Complement Verbs – in Action

tend

Prices always tend to go up.

**volunt
eer**

She volunteered to help with the food drive.

decide

In the end, we decided to go on strike.

refuse

They refused to answer any questions.

**manag
e**

He managed to finish the project on time.

claim

She claims to have seen a UFO last night.

**threat
en**

They threatened to cancel the contract.

seem

He seems to be younger than he really is.

**promis
e**

The principal promised to look into the matter.

**preten
d**

Joe pretended not to notice the mistake.

Special Phrases + Infinitive

be about to

He is just about to leave.

be able to

Are you able to drive in the dark?

can't afford to

We can't afford to live in the centre.

take the trouble to

He took the trouble to answer personally.

do one's best to

She did her best to pass the exam.

make every effort to

The police make every effort to reduce crime.

make up one's mind to

He hasn't made up his mind to wait for them.

set out to

They set out to discover a cure for cancer.

turn out to

She turned out to know him from childhood.

it occurs to sb to

It occurred to me to call her first.

Negation & Timing with Infinitives

NEGATION

not is placed BEFORE the infinitive:

- › *Joe pretended not to notice.*
- › *I decided not to go to the party.*
- › *She asked us not to be late.*

SINGULAR VERB RULE

To work hard is important.

To travel alone seems scary.

To study daily appears effective.

✗ *To arrive late are rude.*

✓ *To arrive late IS rude.*

TIMING (Perfect Infinitive)

Use to have + past participle when the infinitive action happened BEFORE the main verb:

- › *He claims to have met the President. (before claiming)*
- › *She appears to have left already. (before appearing)*
- › *They proved to have known the truth. (before proving)*
- › *The treatment proved to have been a mistake.*

The Bare Infinitive (without 'to')

CAUSATIVE VERBS

make • let • have

- › *She made us wait for half an hour.*
- › *John lets the dog sleep on the sofa.*
- › *I'll have them fix the car by noon.*

PERCEPTION VERBS

see • hear • watch • feel • notice

- › *I saw him leave the building.*
- › *She heard the baby cry at night.*
- › *We watched the sun rise over the hills.*

⚠ After HELP: both forms are acceptable – 'She helped me (to) carry the bags.'

Quick Reference Summary

1 As Subject

To travel is exciting.
→ Use 'it' structure:
It is exciting to travel.

2 As Complement

I want to learn.
She decided to stay.
He refused to speak.

3 Bare Infinitive

Make / let / have + bare inf:
She made him apologize.
Let the children play.

4 Special Phrases

be about to / afford to
make up one's mind to
set out to / turn out to

5 Negation

NOT before the infinitive:
He pretended not to know.
She decided not to come.

6 Perfect Infinitive

Action before main verb:
He claims to have seen it.
She appears to have left.

Practice Exercises

1. She _____ to call me, but she forgot. (promise)

2. The children were made _____ in silence. (sit)

3. It _____ impossible to save money these days. (seem)

4. He claimed _____ the CEO personally. (meet)

5. They set _____ climb the mountain at dawn. (out)

6. She decided _____ take the job offer. (not)
Answer: not to

7. _____ is very brave to travel alone. (It)

8. The police make every _____ reduce crime. (effort)
Answer: effort to

Keep Practicing!

The infinitive is one of the most versatile tools in English grammar.

✓ Practise transforming to-infinitive ↔ it-structure

✓ Memorise the key verb lists with examples

✓ Pay attention to bare vs. to-infinitive contexts

✓ Use perfect infinitives for actions in the past